

better pair of headphones.

HTC Tattoo features a 3.15 MP auto-focus camera that takes snaps at a 2048 x 1536 pixel resolution. Video photography is also possible with this camera. Users can download or transfer video files and play them in the integrated video playback. This is capable of playing video files of different formats such as MP4, WMV9, H.263 and H.264.

A nice little feature is that when you lock your phone, you can still fool around with your music as much as you want, without the hassle of going into the Tattoo's OS.

Battery life

After some rigorous playing with the Tattoo—which included downloading many apps, playing myriad videos and songs, and a lot of Web surfing—the battery held up pretty decently. While the actual service time of the battery was nowhere near HTC's claim of 350 minutes, it wasn't too bad either.

One of the things I found was when charging the phone on the computer, the handset did get very warm near the micro USB connection. This happened on more than one occasion, but it soon cooled down once I stopped charging it.

Another excellent little add-on comes courtesy Android 1.6, and that is a battery indicator that gives you a break-down of what your battery is being used for. This is a great way to keep track of whether or not you have closed down those unwanted apps.

And there are plenty of organising apps to sap your battery power if you so wish. There is a mixed bag of goodies on offer, including Google apps like Mail, Maps and Talk, and options including a calculator, calendar and FM radio.

I like it... very much

Ultimately, if the Android OS is ever going to win mass-market appeal, it is phones like the HTC Tattoo that will make this happen. Packing everything that is good about Android into a

lower-cost handset just proves how good Google's OS and marketing skills are. And HTC has really made its mark re-skinning the OS to make it its own, and once again the HTC Tattoo proves that the Sense UI is one of the best things to happen to Android, since its inception.

The compact form of the phone and the stylish design are among the best features of HTC Tattoo. Moreover, the wide range of high-end features makes the phone a must-have for Android fans who cannot buy themselves more expensive smartphones, such as the Hero or Magic.

I like it... not so much

The screen was lacklustre, with nowhere near the amount of zing that you get when using a capacitive rival. And when it came to the camera capabilities it was just, well, average. I think an accelerometer and multi-touch features would've been great to have. Also, perhaps Flash for the browser and more features for the music player.

It also disappointed when it came to text messaging. It's just not feasible to text quickly when the phone is in portrait mode. You will need to flip it into landscape and even then the predictive text will try and be evil—it feels like it works against you, not with you.

Another problem with the HTC Tattoo is that it seems to have adopted the same predictive text model as the HTC Hero. And just like Hero, it needs quite a few hours' tinkering before you manage to discover where you can disable the 'feature'.

On the whole the system is fine, but unless you are constantly looking at it, it will give you predictive words that you don't want. Keeping an eye on this and making sure that you are hitting the right letters is a bit of a pain.

It also has to be said that as the phone uses a resistive screen, you have to be even more precise in the hitting of letters and apply a bit more pressure than you would with a capacitive screen. I know that this type of screen has been used as a cost-cutting measure, but it does feel like a backward step for HTC, as it used capacitive screens on both the Magic and the Hero.

The verdict?

Frankly, I am in two minds about the HTC Tattoo. On the one hand, it's a likeable, compact Android smartphone running the cool Sense interface. On the other, the concessions the manufacturer has had to make to keep the price low are neither minor, nor just a few. I don't really have a problem with the screen size itself, but the lower resolution is equivalent to extremely poor catalogue of applications compatible with the device. This is a bitter pill to swallow and definitely something one is unwilling to put up with. More so, now, when Android seems to be making evolutionary leaps forward and its development is picking up speed.

The unhandy resistive technology incorporated into the display and the barren waste that the application catalogue for the device is, paired with all the other minor yet real drawbacks of the handset, would have made the HTC Tattoo a viable option if it was available at an affordable price. Sadly, this is not the case. In case you are flat out determined to get a cell phone delivering the handy features of the socially-oriented Sense interface, I would definitely advise you to consider the HTC Hero—it's price is not that much higher now, and the handset is head and shoulders above the Tattoo. 

By: Sayantan Pal

More popular in the online world as Shayon, he runs a review blog on Howzzit.com and also works as "the SMM guy" at Pronto Networks. Catch up with him on twitter (@shayonpal) or shoot him an e-mail (me@shayonpal.com) anytime you want.